

HARDIK CHHABRA

"I've found that a combination of diets works best for me. Time is also scarce, so I find it easier to diet on my own without a nutritionist. I went from 136 kg to 105 kg in 2020 simply by controlling how much and what I eat"

HITESH KUKREJA, 48

DELHI

Fashion businessman

Navya Agarwal, a 32-year-old MBA student from Bengaluru, had to take a year off studies after an internet-inspired diet went wrong. For four months, she ate only vegetables and eggs. The aim was to cut out all gluten, which Navya mistakenly believed to mean carbohydrates, forsaking even rice, which is naturally gluten-free. "One day, I fainted from exhaustion," she says. "I felt tired and stressed and couldn't study for a year." It took her a year of close dietary monitoring by a doctor to improve her health. There's also 48-year-old Hitesh Kukreja from Delhi, who has experimented with at least 20 different diet plans to date. "I have realised there's no one diet plan that works for me," he says. "I get bored and need variety. Currently, he is on a programme that allows for only one of three dishes for breakfast: poha, upma or idli, with lots of vegetables; lunch is bottle gourd with some salt and oil, and dinner pumpkin soup minus salt. It's the same menu every day.

Agarwal and Kukreja are among a growing number of Indians who have made drastic changes to their diets in the past few years. "I call it the 'circus of diets'," says noted clinical nutritionist and author Ishi Khosla. "There has been a growth in types of diets since the 1970s, but the pace has increased now. Every few months, the industry has a new diet, a new meal plan, a new nutrition mantra as people look for an answer to growing lifestyle diseases."

Indeed, one in four Indians was found to be overweight in the National Family Health Survey-5 (NFHS) of 2019-21, compared to one in five Indians in NFHS-4 (2015-16). The 10th edition of the 'Diabetes Atlas', a report published by the International Diabetes Federation, an umbrella body of over 240 national diabetes associations in 160 countries and territories, estimates that over 74 million adults in India, or one in 12 adults, is living with diabetes. There have been numerous reports of rising Polycystic Ovary Syndrome (PCOS) cases, a hormonal disorder that causes cysts to develop on the outer edge of ovaries (one in five women in India have PCOS according to Metropolis Healthcare), as well as of hypothyroidism cases, a condition in which the body doesn't produce enough thyroid hormones (one in 10 Indians according to the Indian Thyroid Society suffer from hypothyroidism).